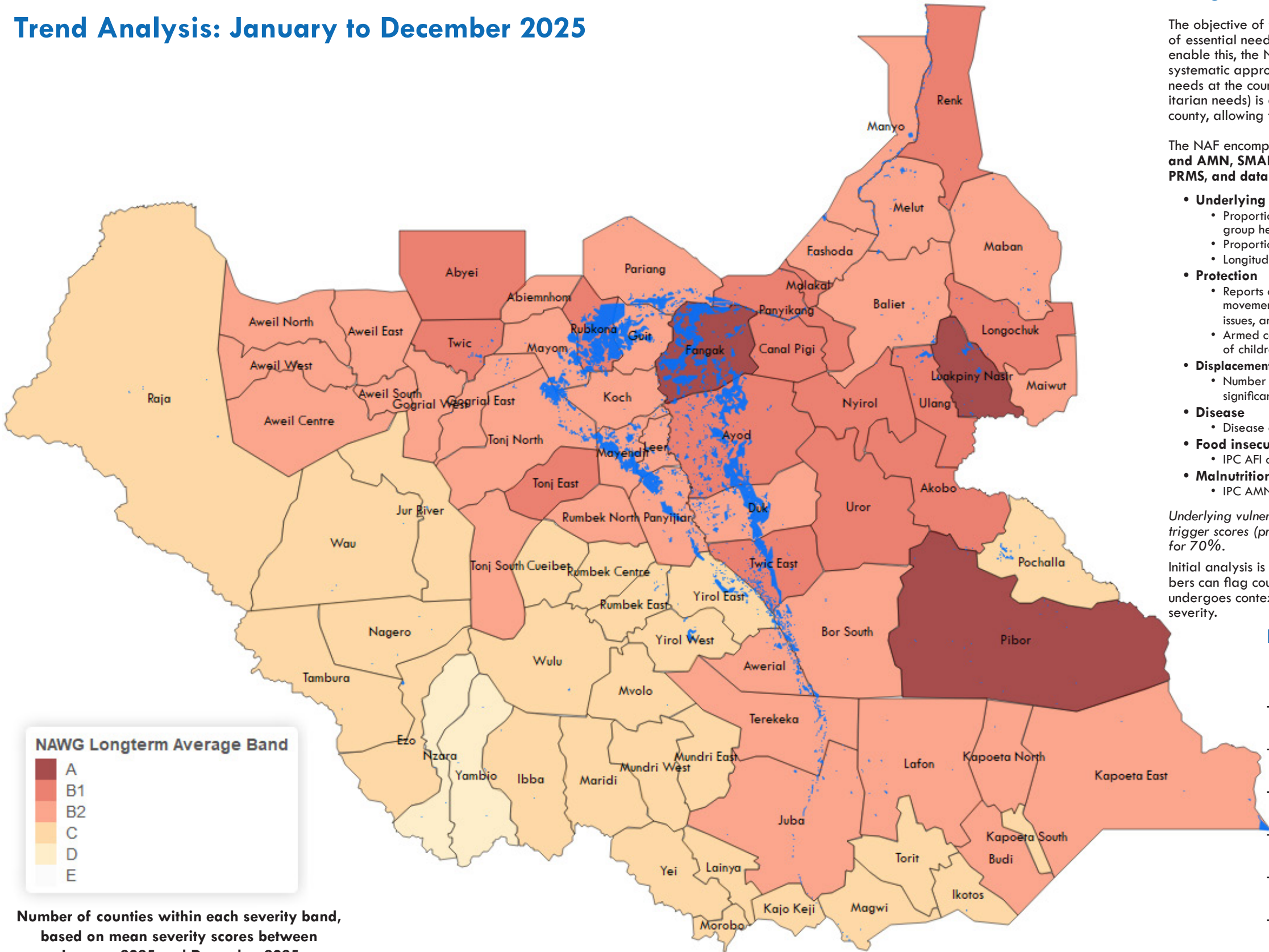


SOUTH SUDAN - NEEDS ANALYSIS WORKING GROUP (NAWG)

Trend Analysis: January to December 2025



Background

The objective of the NAWG is to conduct evidence-based and contextualized analysis of essential needs across South Sudan to inform decision-making and prioritization. To enable this, the NAWG analytical framework (NAF) was developed. The NAF provides a systematic approach to interpret a wide array of multi-sectoral information and monitor needs at the county-level. The final classification (ranging from extreme to minor humanitarian needs) is an intersectoral measure of the severity of humanitarian conditions in a county, allowing for comparative analysis between counties and across time.

The NAF encompasses data from a variety of sources (including **FSNMS, ISNA, IPC AFI and AMN, SMART surveys, JMMI, ACLED, IRNAs, REACH data, IOM DTM, WHO IDSR, PRMS, and data from Clusters**) which inform the following indicators:

- Underlying vulnerability**
 - Proportion of female-headed households, child-headed households and other vulnerable-group headed households
 - Proportion of IDPs and/or returnees compared to host communities
 - Longitudinal food insecurity
- Protection**
 - Reports of explosive hazards, lack of access to humanitarian assistance, restriction of movement, sexual violence, family separation, HLP issues, child labour, civil documentation issues, among others
 - Armed conflict events and/or conflict-related sexual violence and/or forced recruitment of children and/or targeted killings of civilians and/or targeted property destruction
- Displacement**
 - Number of displaced persons arriving and/or number of returnees returning, as significant numbers of arrivals has the potential to exacerbate food and resource access
- Disease**
 - Disease outbreaks, including cholera, measles, meningitis, and malaria, among others
- Food insecurity**
 - IPC AFI classifications are used for each county
- Malnutrition**
 - IPC AMN and SMART surveys are used to assess acute malnutrition severity (GAM/SAM)

Underlying vulnerability accounts for 30% of the overall severity score, while the first-level trigger scores (protection, displacement, disease, food insecurity and malnutrition) account for 70%.

Initial analysis is shared with NAWG members ahead of each monthly meeting and members can flag counties for discussion. During the NAWG meeting, each flagged county undergoes contextual analysis before the assignment of a final band based on needs severity.

Needs Severity Classifications

Severity band	Indicator threshold	Severity level definitions
A	8 - 10	Extreme humanitarian conditions
B1	7 - 7.9	Severe humanitarian conditions (higher severity)
B2	6 - 6.9	Severe humanitarian conditions (lower severity)
C	4 - 5.9	Moderate humanitarian conditions
D	2 - 3.9	Stressed humanitarian conditions
E	0 - 1.9	Minor or acceptable humanitarian conditions

Mean Severity Score

The mean score for each county was calculated using the monthly scores from the 10 NAWG analysis months in 2025 (Jan–Jul, Oct–Dec). When the band for a county was increased during a NAWG meeting based on contextual analysis among members, the score was increased to the minimum score in the new band (e.g. if a county was increased to band A, the score was increased to 8.00 to match the band's minimum severity score). Similarly, if the band was decreased during the NAWG meeting, the score was decreased to the maximum score for the new band (e.g. if a county was decreased to band B2, the score was decreased to 6.9).

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Introduction and Methodology

South Sudan's humanitarian needs in 2025 remained acute and widespread, driven by compounding intersectoral crises across protection, displacement, disease, food insecurity, and malnutrition. The Needs Analysis Working Group (NAWG) monitors these needs through a structured analytical framework, producing a Needs Severity Score (NSS) for each of the country's 79 counties on a scale of 0-10.

The NSS combines an **Underlying Vulnerability Score (UVS)**, capturing structural factors, with an **Aggregate Trigger Score (ATS)**, capturing acute shocks and triggers. In the 2025 framework, underlying vulnerabilities contribute 30% of the NSS while acute intersectoral triggers contribute 70%. Counties are then classified into severity Bands A-E, from Extreme (score 8-10) to Minor (below 2). Methodological restrictions ensure that counties in IPC AFI Phase 5 are automatically assigned Band A, and counties in IPC Phase 4 (food insecurity or malnutrition) are kept at minimum Band B2.

The NAWG monthly severity classifications were produced for 10 months in 2025 (January–July and October–December). Analysis was paused in August–September due to the IPC cycle and corresponding data gaps; therefore, the trend analysis is based on these 10 analysed months in 2025.

Overall Trend Analysis

The 2025 analysis period began with an already elevated baseline compared to the previous year. At the start of the year, the share of counties in high severity (Band A or B1) had risen to 31%, up from 22% at the start of 2024 – representing a 9 percentage point increase year-on-year. The average NSS across all counties rose from 5.91 to 6.22 over the same period. This worsened baseline set the stage for a challenging year, with **nearly all counties reaching Bands B2, B1, or A (severe to extremely severity) at some point in the year, and none reaching the negligible needs Band E at any time during 2025.**

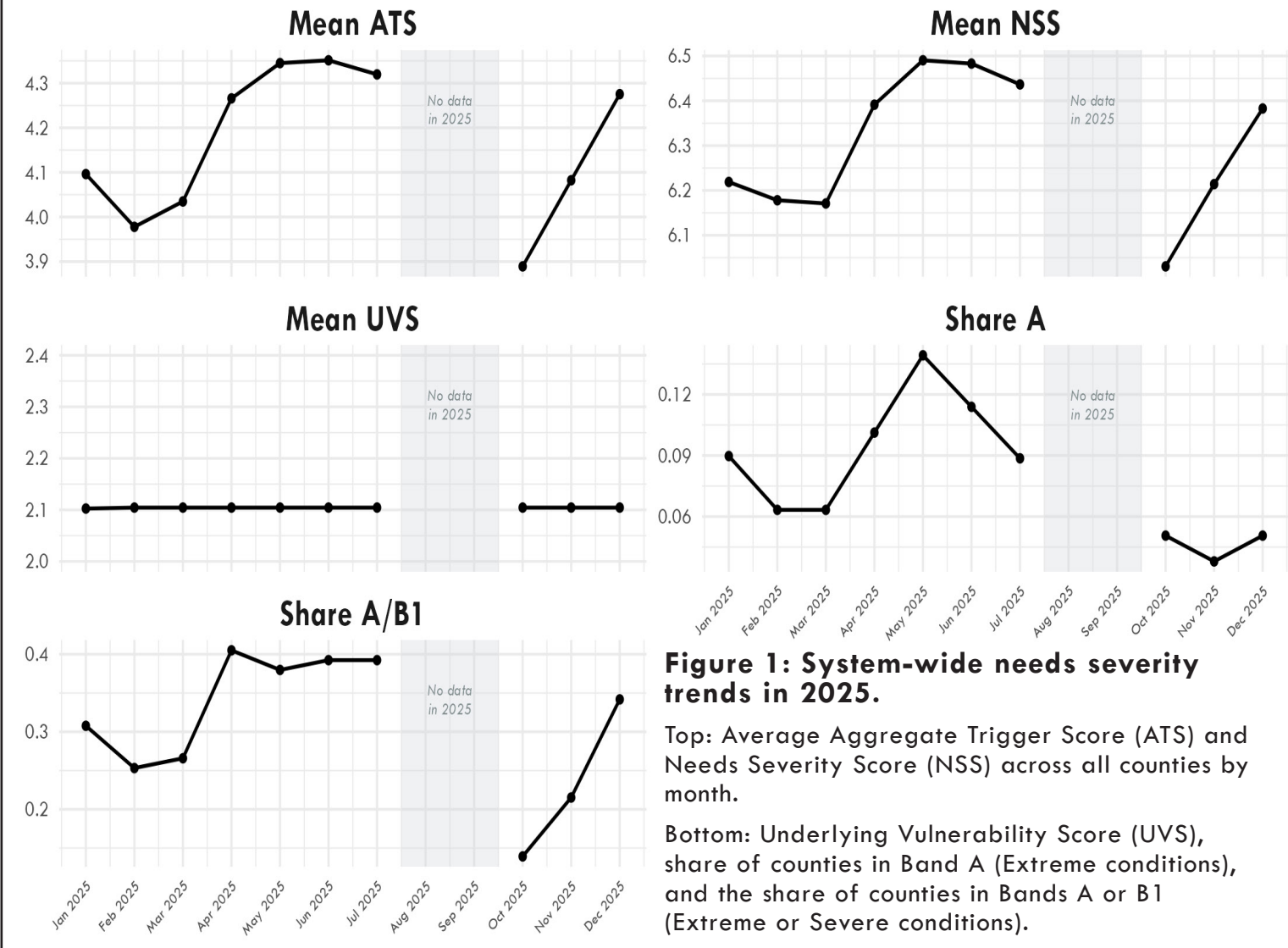
As Figure 1 illustrates, the humanitarian situation followed the expected seasonal pattern, peaking mid-2025 during the traditional lean season and showing partial relief in the latter part of the year. The Mean NSS climbed to its highest levels around May–June 2025, when food insecurity and malnutrition were at their worst. Between March and June 2025, 39-41% of counties were classified in Band A or B1 – with the mean NSS peaking 6.49 in April–May and remaining elevated into May–June.

Following the main harvest season, conditions eased substantially. By October 2025, the Band A/B1 share dropped to just 14% – the lowest point of the year – as improved food availability translated into lower overall severity scores. However, this improvement proved temporary. A secondary uptick in severity occurred in November 2025, driven primarily by a surge in disease outbreaks (86% of counties in “High” or “Very High”) and continued protection concerns (57% of counties in elevated status). This pushed the Band A/B1 share back up to 34% by year-end, demonstrating that gains from improved food security can be quickly offset by deterioration in other pillars.

Intersectoral Pillar Trends

A defining feature of NAWG analysis is its intersectoral approach, capturing the major drivers and outcomes of acute humanitarian crises through five pillars: Protection, Displacement, Disease Outbreaks, Food Insecurity, and Malnutrition. Each pillar is scored

NAWG 2025: Core Scores Over Time



on a severity scale (Low, Moderate, High, Very High), and together they form the bulk of the ATS which drives 70% of the overall NSS. In 2025, trends across these pillars were not uniform – some showed improvement while others deteriorated significantly, with distinct seasonal patterns that influenced the overall intersectoral severity outcomes.

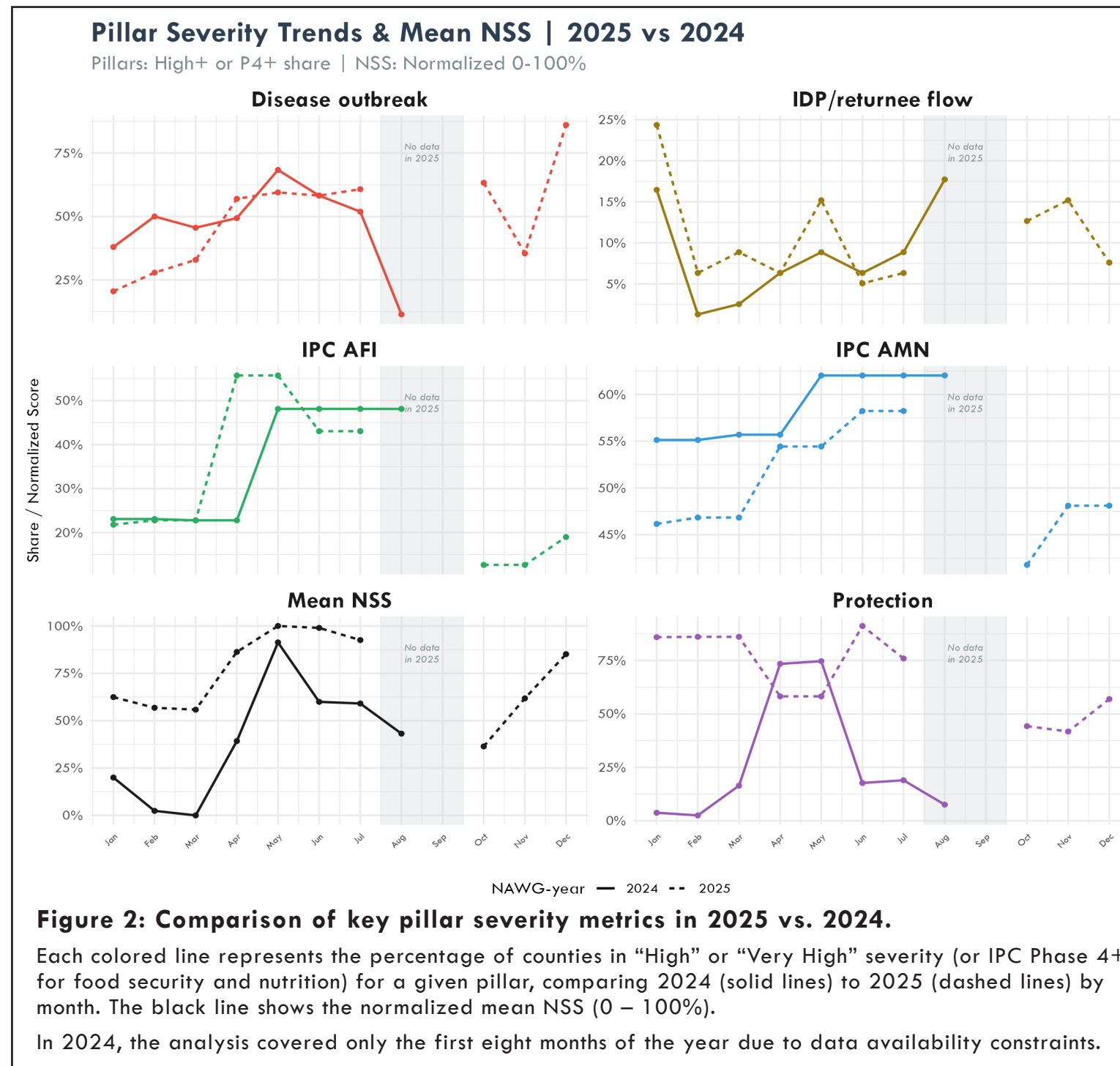
Food Insecurity

Food insecurity followed the characteristic lean season pattern, with IPC AFI Phase 4+ (Emergency or worse) prevalence peaking at 54% of counties in April–July 2025. This indicates that over half of South Sudan's counties faced emergency-level food insecurity during the worst months of the hunger season. Post-harvest improvements were substantial and consistent with seasonal expectations.

IPC AFI Phase 4+ prevalence dropped to 13% of counties by October as harvests improved food availability across much of the country. However, a modest increase to 19% of counties was observed by December, suggesting that some areas were already experiencing renewed

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food stress even before the next lean season. Persistent crisis areas included Jonglei, Upper Nile, Unity, and Warrap states, which sustained IPC AFI Phase 4 or 5 conditions across multiple months regardless of seasonal improvements elsewhere.

Malnutrition

Acute malnutrition followed a similar seasonal pattern to food insecurity but with a notable lag in recovery. **The percentage of counties facing IPC AMN Phase 4+ (Critical or worse) peaked at 62% in May–June 2025, representing over half the country with GAM or SAM rates above emergency thresholds.** This staggering breadth of nutritional crisis reflects

the cumulative impact of food shortages, disease, and limited access to health and nutrition services.

Unlike food security, malnutrition recovery was markedly slower. While food insecurity dropped to 13% of counties facing IPC AFI Phase 4+ by October, **malnutrition remained elevated as 48% of counties were still in AMN Phase 4 by October 2025.** This divergence reflects the compounding effects of disease burden, limited health and nutrition service access in many areas, and the physiological lag between improved food intake and nutritional recovery. The persistence of critical malnutrition even after food availability improved kept many counties’ overall NSS elevated throughout the latter part of the year.

Protection Risks

Perhaps the most dramatic change in 2025 was the surge in protection-related severity. In 2024, protection risks were more localized, with only 17–19% of counties in “High” / “Very High” protection status during the May–June period. By contrast, 2025 saw a dramatic expansion of protection concerns nationwide. The share of counties with “High” or “Very High” protection severity spiked to 91% by May 2025, meaning virtually all counties had substantial protection risks.

This nationwide elevation likely reflects both shifting protection conditions amid expanding conflict/insecurity into previously stable areas and improved reporting that captures latent risks. Intensification of sub-national conflicts and cattle-raiding violence in areas like Warrap, Lakes, and parts of Equatoria during 2025 likely contributed to elevated protection scores outside traditional conflict hotspots. The protection pillar dipped in the second half of 2025 as acute incidents subsided in some areas, but by year-end 57% of counties remained in “High” or “Very High” protection status – a substantially higher baseline than the corresponding period in 2024.

It is important to note that the ATS formula weights the protection pillar at 1 out of 7 points, so even universally “High” protection scores alone would not automatically place all counties in extreme needs bands. However, elevated protection risks added to cumulative pressure in combination with other pillars, and for counties already facing food insecurity or malnutrition crises, often meant reduced humanitarian access and worsened outcomes.

Displacement (IDPs and Returnees)

Displacement is captured in two dimensions: the stock of displaced populations (accumulated over years of conflict and climate shocks) and the flow of new displacement or return movements. In 2025, the displacement stock remained at effectively universal levels, with 98% of counties above the “High” severity threshold for IDP/returnee presence throughout the year (the NAWG framework considers >10% IDP/returnee presence as “Very High” severity level, which most counties far exceeded). This reflects the protracted nature of displacement in South Sudan, where years of conflict and repeated flooding have left most communities hosting significant displaced populations. This near-universal displacement burden contributes a constant baseline to county ATS scores, keeping the floor of severity elevated everywhere.

New displacement flows were episodic and somewhat less widespread than in 2024. Peak months (May and October) saw 12–15% of counties experiencing “High” influx or outflow of displaced persons, while calmer periods saw this drop to 5–8%.

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The lower incidence of large-scale displacement events in 2025 compared to 2024 contributed to the relatively lower overall severity during certain months, though when displacement spikes did occur, they created acute humanitarian needs in affected areas.

Nevertheless, **nearly every county hosted a significant number of displaced people throughout 2025**, and many experienced intermittent surges of new displacement. This combination meant displacement was a constant driver of humanitarian need – either as a chronic strain on host communities and services or as acute crises when people fled or returned in large numbers.

Disease Outbreaks

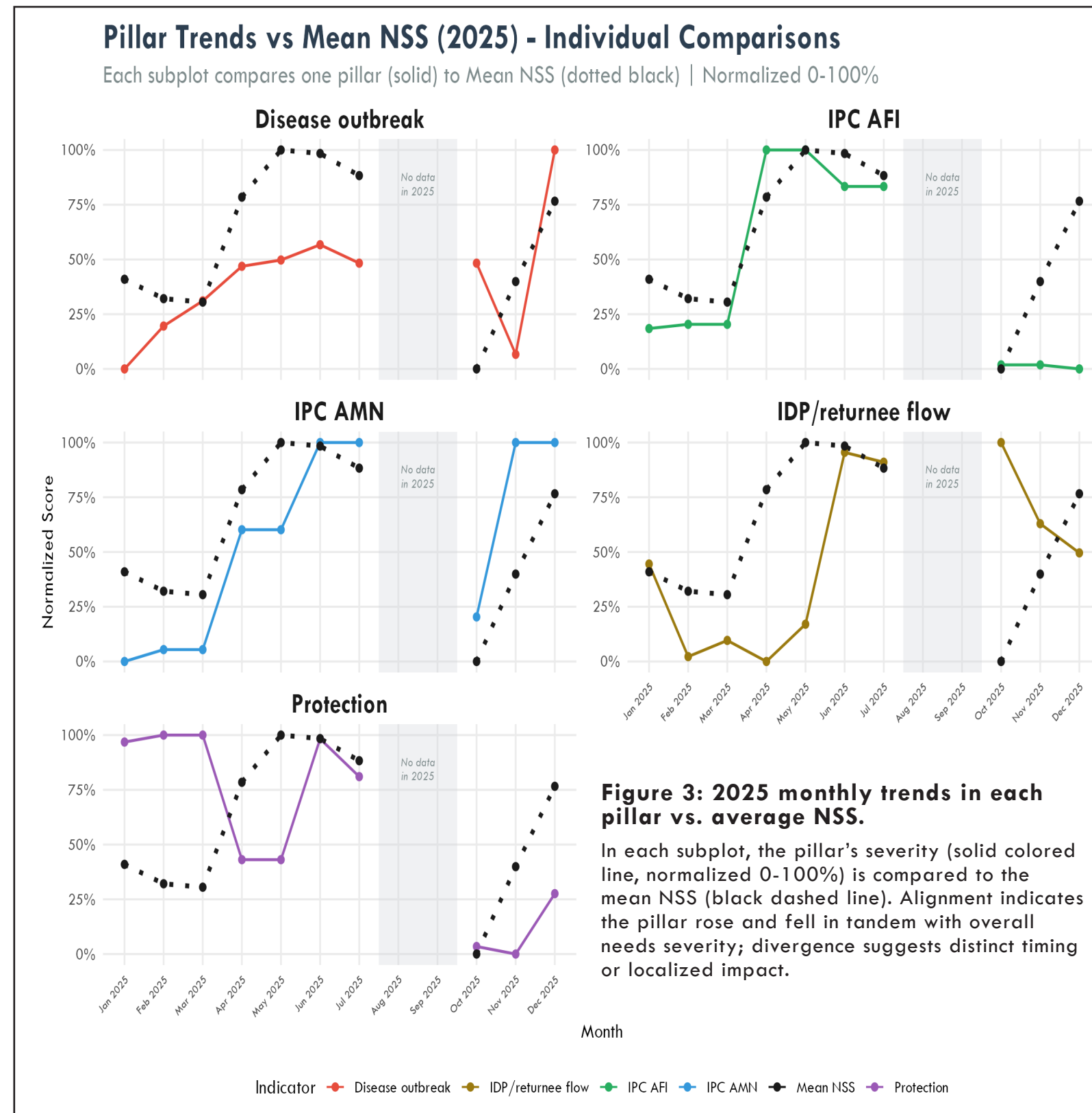
Public health threats were another major factor, with 2025 seeing a notable deterioration compared to 2024. Both years exhibited a mid-year increase in disease outbreaks (around 58% of counties were in “High” or “Very High” disease incidence or outbreak status by mid-2024, and around the same level at 58% in mid-2025). These mid-year peaks correspond to the rainy season uptick in malaria, water-borne disease, and other endemic illnesses, as well as outbreaks (e.g. measles or cholera) that often flare up in the wet months. This deterioration was compounded by South Sudan’s largest recorded cholera outbreak, which began in September 2024 and remained widespread throughout the year, reaching roughly 95,000 suspected cases and about 1,600 deaths by late October 2025.

Consequently, **2025 experienced a more complex and multi-hazard crisis profile** than 2024 in certain respects. Food security and nutrition remained extremely severe but followed expected seasonal patterns and were marginally less dire at peak than the year prior. In contrast, protection and public health conditions markedly worsened or spread to new areas in 2025, offsetting gains from improved harvests. Displacement continued to underpin needs across virtually the entire country, with new displacement spikes reflecting recurring shocks (conflict outbreaks, floods). The interplay of these pillars largely determined each county’s intersectoral severity classification over the year.

Needs Severity Outcomes and County Typologies

The combined effect of the pillars described above is reflected in the NSS and final severity bands for each county. Counties with consistently extreme pillar scores across the board – simultaneous critical food insecurity, high malnutrition, active conflict, and disease outbreaks – were those that remained in Band A (Extreme humanitarian conditions) for prolonged periods. Understanding how counties cluster into distinct typologies based on their 2025 trajectories provides insight into the different patterns of humanitarian need across South Sudan.

As shown in Figure 3, food security and malnutrition trends were closely aligned with the overall NSS curve – when half the country is in IPC AFI/AMN Phase 4, overall severity inevitably peaks. By contrast, the protection and disease pillars exhibited substantial divergence at times. Protection severity spiked early in the year and remained erratic, indicating that while protection risks were widespread, their translation into extreme NSS bands depended on concurrent factors in other pillars. Similarly, the late-year disease surge came after the main hunger season peak, contributing to a secondary NSS bump but operating somewhat independently of the food-driven severity cycle.



To better understand how humanitarian need evolved across South Sudan in 2025, counties were grouped into **band-based typologies** based on how consistently they remained in higher or lower NAWG severity bands across the **10 analysed months** (Jan–Jul, Oct–Dec). This approach focuses on **time spent in each severity range**, capturing whether a county’s needs were persistently extreme, persistently severe, persistently moderate/stressed, or more mixed across the year.

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In parallel, **volatility** is treated as a separate typology, distinguishing counties where severity scores fluctuate sharply month-to-month from those with more stable trajectories.

Chronic High

Counties classified as **chronic high** spent 8 or more months in Band A or B1 during 2025, with needs that were uniformly severe rather than fluctuating. **These 14 counties represent the protracted emergency core of South Sudan's humanitarian crisis. Malakal, Pibor, Nasir, Canal/Pigi, Malakal, and Fangak each spent all 10 analysed months in Band A or B1**, while Rubkona, Uror, Abyei, and Ulang spent 9 months in these severe bands. Renk, Tonj East, Twic East, Akobo, and Nyirol each spent 8 months in high severity.

These counties share common characteristics: **multiple concurrent drivers operating simultaneously (conflict, sustained food insecurity, flooding, displacement), geographic concentration in Upper Nile, Jonglei, and Unity states, and humanitarian conditions that never truly eased during 2025.** For these areas, seasonal improvements elsewhere in the country did not translate into meaningful relief – they remained in crisis throughout the year.

Chronic Mid

Chronic Mid counties spent **8 or more months in Bands A–B2** (severe or worse), but did not meet the Chronic High threshold of 8+ months in A/B1. This is the largest “high-severity persistence” group, comprising **30 counties**, and it reflects the reality that much of the country experienced a **high baseline of severity in 2025** even when not continuously at the very top bands.

Within this group, some counties repeatedly hovered near the threshold of extreme severity, spending 6–7 months in A/B1 while still remaining in severe bands for nearly the entire year (e.g., Aweil East, Ayod, Longochuk, Twic (Warrap), Duk, Tonj North). Others had fewer months in A/B1 but remained consistently severe at Band B2 or above (e.g., Guit, Leer, Mayendit, Panyijiar, Mayom, Maban, Aweil North/West/South, Fashoda, Melut, Manyo, Baliet).

Moderate (Mixed Trajectories)

Counties classified as **Moderate** did not spend 8+ months in either the severe-or-worse group (A–B2) or the moderate/stressed group (C–D–E). Instead, they show more mixed trajectories, often moving between Band B2 and Band C (and occasionally shifting higher or lower depending on the season and shocks). This group includes **18 counties** such as Maiwut, Lafon, Tonj South, Kapoeta North/East/South, Tambura, Nagero, Raja, Yirol East/West, Rumbek North/East, Pariang, Jur River, Wau, Torit, Lainya, Terekeka.

These are counties where the year's pattern is best understood as **intermittent pressure rather than persistent severity**: periods of elevated severity during the lean season or during localised shocks, followed by partial improvement post-harvest or when acute stressors recede. These “mixed” profiles show that a county can be outside chronic-high categories while still experiencing repeated episodes of severe need.

Chronic Low

Chronic Low counties spent **8 or more months in Bands C–D–E**, indicating comparatively lower (though still significant) needs severity for most of the year.

This group includes **17 counties**, concentrated largely in parts of the Equatorias, such as **Ikotos, Ibba, Maridi, Nzara, Yambio, Yei, Wulu**, as well as counties that mostly remained in moderate/stressed bands but had brief periods of higher severity (e.g., Kajo-keji, Magwi, Mvolo, Mundri West/East, Morobo, Cueibet, Rumbek Centre, Pochalla, Ezo).

It is important to interpret “Chronic Low” carefully in the South Sudan context: **being largely in Bands C/D does not imply negligible needs**, but rather that these counties did not persistently meet the thresholds associated with severe-to-extreme banding during the analysed months. Many still face meaningful protection risks, service access constraints, and seasonal stress, but with relatively fewer months at the top bands compared to the rest of the country.

Volatility as a Separate Typology

In addition to band persistence, counties were also classified by **volatility**, measured by how much the Needs Severity Score fluctuated across the analysed months. **High-volatility (“shocky”)** counties (NSS volatility ≥ 0.75) show sharp swings, consistent with **episodic shocks** or rapidly changing conditions rather than steady deterioration or steady recovery. In 2025, **10 counties** fell into this category, including **Mundri West, Magwi, Mvolo, Jur River, Ezo, Longochuk, Lainya, Lafon, Tonj North, and Kajo-keji**. The remaining counties were **comparatively stable**, where month-to-month changes occurred but within a narrower range. Volatility is analytically useful because it flags places where risk can escalate quickly, even if the county does not spend most months in the highest bands.

Geographic Patterns

In terms of geographic patterns, the data reveal clustering consistent with known regional vulnerabilities. The Eastern flood belt and conflict belt spanning Upper Nile, Jonglei, and Unity contained most of the chronic high-need counties, suffering from compounding effects of conflict, displacement, and climatic shocks. Western Equatoria and parts of Central Equatoria saw relatively moderate conditions, aligning with areas that enjoyed comparative calm and better market access in 2025. Lakes, Warrap, and parts of Greater Bahr el Ghazal showed more of the shock-driven profiles – generally mid-level needs punctuated by episodes of violence or localized crises.

Conclusion

The humanitarian needs trends in 2025 demonstrate that South Sudan is under persistent, multi-faceted pressure. While seasonal improvements occurred – particularly post-harvest food security gains – these were offset by expanding crises in protection and public health, alongside the persistent burden of displacement, hunger, and malnutrition that affects nearly all of South Sudan.

Several key analytical findings emerge from the 2025 NAWG data. **No county reached Band E (negligible needs) at any point during the year, confirming that humanitarian need remains universal across South Sudan.** The 2025 baseline was elevated compared to 2024, with 31% of counties in Band A/B1 at year-start versus 22% the previous year, and mean NSS of 6.22 versus 5.91. Seasonal patterns followed the expected lean season trajectory, but post-harvest improvements were partially offset by protection risks expansion and disease surge. Food security and malnutrition pillars remained the primary drivers of overall severity, with over 50% of counties in IPC Phase 4+ (AFI and AMN) during peak months.